NITISH'S BIHAR CHALLENGE

- The *mahagathbandhan* has to make good on their poll promises. To project Bihar as a governance success before 2024, Nitish must move towards the creation of two million jobs that he promised on August 15
- There has to be greater coordination between the RJD and JD(U). Two RJD ministers have quit their posts in the last two months
- Free from anti-incumbency, the BJP would consolidate and target the Nitish-Tejashwi combine ahead of the 2024 LS polls
- Nitish's JD(U) has the finance portfolio. The state raises nearly one-fourth of its revenue from its own sources, 46 per cent comes from the Centre as Bihar's share in central taxes and another quarter from central grants. Any delay from the Centre can make it difficult for Bihar to meet its governance goals

they will be able to continue after 2024." It was nothing less than a throwing down of the gauntlet to Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Clearly, though he still remains the diligent CM, sitting through hours-long meetings and poring over every document placed before him, the 71-year-old socialist now has a political focus beyond his home state. Indeed, his concept of opposition unity ahead of the 2024 polls can be seen as an extension of his seven-party anti-NDA *mahagathbandhan* in Bihar. To be sure, Nitish is projecting it as a template for a national opposition against the BJP.

The big challenge for Nitish now is to replicate such a coalition at the national level, where the BJP is the biggest beast in the political jungle and the opposition appears to be a divided lot. The voters may also look for a personality deemed strong enough to counter PM Modi for the national polls. The task, at every level, is fraught with difficulty.

Take just a few examples. Now that it's clear that the Congress is sought as a coalition partner, the bitter differences between it, the Left Front and the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal will have to be set aside. The Left and the Congress are rivals in Kerala too. With all these regional gulfs to be bridged, one sees why the concept of a grand opposition unity is often dismissed merely as an 'academic idea'.

A senior JD(U) leader disagrees. "Do you think we have not taken into account all of this? This is a time to take one step a day. The leaders whom Nitish Kumar met in New Delhi are all in agreement. It is time to cut down our ambition to ensure the survival of the opposition," he says. He adds that those who cannot join now can come on board in the post-poll scenario.

Nitish seems to be confident. In off-the-record conversations, his aides recall how he made the Communists support his candidature when he contested—and won handsomely—his first Lok Sabha election in 1989 from the Barh constituency in Bihar. Now, 33 years later and with immense governance, and coalition, credentials under his belt, Nitish hopes to work his powers of persuasion on opposition leaders.

SECURING THE HOME FRONT

A section of BJP politicians admit that their party faces a massive challenge in Bihar in 2024, as the combined might of Nitish and Lalu and the social coalition they draw upon appear unassailable on paper. The BJP is certainly not taking things easy. Union home minister Amit Shah addressed a rally in Purnia on September 23; on October 11, he will attend a function in Saran to mark the birth anniversary of socialist icon Jayaprakash Narayan.

Senior BJP leader Sushil Modi, however, rejects claims about the BJP getting jittery. "You cannot compare state elections with Lok Sabha polls. BJP has Narendra Modi, and a national narrative that the opposition just cannot counter, either in Bihar or elsewhere. We have 17 Lok Sabha MPs in Bihar and as per our preliminary assessment, we will win more than twice that number in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls," he says.

Along with the leap on to the national stage, Nitish has to cover the bases in Bihar too. His new government, with RJD's Tejashwi Yadav as his deputy chief minister, has completed two months in office. Though in terms of social strength, the *mahagathbandhan* is formidable—with strong backing from Yadavs, Muslims, Economically Backward Classes, Dalits, and a majority of OBCs (Other Backward Classes)—it has several challenges to deal with. Firstly, any CM hoping to influence the Lok Sabha polls has to present his state as an achievement, like Modi projected Gujarat in 2014. To accomplish that, Nitish must move towards fulfilling his promise of two million government jobs that he made on August 15. Also, his coalition, though strongly forged, has seen two RJD ministers quit their posts. Sugarcane industry minister Kartikeya Singh resigned on August 31 because of a legal case pending against him whereas agriculture minister Sudhakar Singh stepped down on October 2 after open differences with the CM on issues pertaining to his department. While Tejashwi has backed Nitish on making the ministers put in their papers, coordination between the two parties leaves a lot to be desired. Poll strategist Prashant Kishor, who is expected to launch his Bihar-centric party after his Jan Samaj Padyatra, has criticised Nitish Kumar's outreach. He described Nitish's recent meetings with opposition leaders as 'photo-ops'. The BJP, which is now free of anti-incumbency worries, will aggressively consolidate and look for chinks in Nitish and Tejashwi's armour.

Outside Bihar, though, there is a role reversal of sorts for Nitish, as he endeavours to tease out the BJP's weaknesses. It remains to be seen if he can help fashion a unified front out of the babel of opposition voices. ■